

Lecture Notes: Lost Highway and Spatio-Temporal Distortions

- What is it about David Lynch films that is scary?
 - Can be freaked out by characters who act totally bizarrely
 - EG. “there's a fish in the percolator” in first episode of Twin Peaks
 - BUT
 - things that are most freaky:
 - sexual violence
 - Blue Velvet can be almost unwatchable
 - particularly the line when, at the end of a brutal rape scene the victim shows her psychological complicity when she says: “hit me”
 - disruption to time and space
- Is this really the most freaky aspect of Lynch's film?
 - Perhaps it's not as distressing as the conflation of sexuality and violence
 - It is more strongly embedded in an alternate horror tradition
- What is this alternate tradition?
 - A tradition of space and time being violated
 - This tradition can certainly be seen in postmodernism
 - Particularly American
 - Don DeLillo
 - Thomas Pynchon
 - Both of these examples define regular society – particularly capitalism – as linear time
 - The way of countering this is through abandoning linear time
 - Can also be traced back through Beckett into late Modernism
 - One of Beckett's last works, *Worstward Ho* features a malign creator who is not content with “mere bad”
 - Beckett here depicts two entities “atwain”, “Vast of void atween”
 - BUT
 - at the same time, Beckett tells us, the two are “so-said two at once”
 - The entities are both apart and together
 - Wells' *The Time Machine* posits time as a version of space through which we can travel
 - Back to the Future
 - If we move just through time, don't we end up in the void of space because Earth has moved?
 - There are even tentative beginnings of this in the parallels between the Monster and Frankenstein in Mary Shelley's novel

- Although in context of a fight, the monster says: “I will not be tempted to set myself in opposition to thee”
- The creature is unable to live without Frankenstein and their fates are bound together
- They are, in several ways, the same person
- technical philosophical stance that is being violated here is Kant's *Transcendental Aesthetic*
 - meaning: an aesthetic (way of perceiving or structuring) that is transcendental (absolutely necessary) and brought to the scene BY THE PERCEIVER, not inherent in reality
 - Kant says that it is entirely necessary to have space and time for any of our perceptions to make sense
 - Can you imagine anything without space?
 - Can you imagine anything without time?
 - Kant has many other questions, one of which is: is time just a form of space?
 - ie. do we perceive time because of changes in space that we put in an order
 - What is important here, though, is that we see in Lynch, at the creepiest points, the violation of this stance
 - I want to consider both of these aspects today, starting with space
 - Let's watch some Lost Highway
 - Play party scene
 - There's a couple of questions surrounding this scene that are worth paying attention to
 - 1.) How is it framed from a cinematic point of view
 - 2.) How is the spatial violation communicated?
 - Let's think about the first of these points
 - When you are doing dialogue between two characters in a film, there are several ways you can shoot it
 - 1.) You can have both characters in the frame, talking to one another, both visible
 - This scene does not do this
 - 2.) You can have a switching viewpoint which sits raised and behind the character being spoken to. This allows a better shot of the face of the person speaking, while still making it clear that there are two participants whose purpose, for this scene, is to talk to one another.
 - This scene does not do this.
 - 3.) What this scene in Lost Highway does is to shoot each character in isolation. The Mystery Man gets the full screen, then Frank gets the whole screen, switching between the two. This gives Lynch maximum screen space for Frank's look of horror, but also for a good hard look at the creepy Mystery Man.
 - It also does something else
 - One of literary and cinematic criticism's modes is to find parallels between the minute and the macro
 - To look for instances where the medium replicates, at the smallest levels, the

themes that are present in a work's narrative

- So, although we recognise form and content as a false dichotomy, part of what we try to do critically is to:
 - Make the false distinction for the sake of argument
 - Expose the distinction as false by finding the instances of overlap
- One of these instances can be found here
 - The cinematic medium presents an illusion of depth from what we know is flat
 - Thinking about this further, it seems that the switching between characters does, at some level, give us this formal parallel
 - When the Mystery Man talks of being in two places at the same time, it is overlayed, at the cinematic, micro level with an environment which mirrors this
 - The Mystery Man and Frank occupy the same space
- This parallels the first true moment of shock in the film
 - when Patricia Arquette's character is replaced by the Mystery Man
 - We are led to believe, because it happens only fleetingly that this is merely a hallucination on Frank's part
 - The Mystery Man confirms that this is not the case
- Second point, then
 - How was this spatial violation communicated?
 - Mobile phone
 - But essentially, it's through tech, the disembodied voice, the uncanniness of the twentieth century
- This phenomenon of the disembodied voice plays another role in Lost Highway
 - Serves to establish the temporal loop that pervades the entire film
 - Let's watch two very short sections, the two instances of Frank uttering the phrase "Dick Laurent is dead"
 - As should be clear by now, it is this same phenomenon of a voice, relayed by electronic technology that instigates the structuring loop and subsequent horror of the film
- What can we make of this?
 - This is a question I would like you to consider in your seminars, but I'd like to put a few ideas out there for discussion
 - 1.) Could this be linked to capitalist paradigms?
 - There are many instances of commodification in Lost Highway, particularly through the elements of pornography.
 - People, in their disembodied, filmic state, become items to be bought and sold for the pleasure of others
 - It is only through technology that such horrors are possible

- This seems to integrate horror, technology and capitalism
- 2.) Although *Lost Highway* does not strike one as a horror film at first glance, can you think of other instances within more generically rooted works where space and time are violated?
- 3.) Finally: if we bring together all of the above, what does Lynch's film seem to say about this conjunction?
 - If the new tradition of horror can be seen in the creepy mediation that technology brings, is there some rejection of technology – Ludditism – at play?
 - I don't have an answer to these questions – I want you to debate it – but I certainly do want to suggest that it is high time that we looked again and again and again and again.

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